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TRANSPORTATION



Uber is finally letting women riders in the US match with women drivers

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against companies like Uber and Lyft. And while rare, reports of sexual assaults and fatal attacks have only fueled those concerns.

Uber reported 36 physical assault fatalities in 2021 and 2022, according to its latest U.S. safety report released last year. Uber noted that physical assault fatalities had jumped from previous years. While the incidents still made up a tiny fraction of the 1.8 billion trips that were made in 2021 and 2022 in the U.S., the uptick prompted the company to launch a variety of features to increase safety, including verified rider badges and options to audio and video record rides.

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prices rise on August 7.

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Sexual assault incidents have dropped consistently since Uber began reporting the data in 2017. Uber reported 5,981 sexual assaults from 2017 to 2018, and that figure dropped by more than half to 2,717 in the 2021 to 2022 period.

Meanwhile, Uber and Lyft have sought ways to attract more female drivers. Both companies have

more male drivers than women — for instance, about one in five Uber drivers in the U.S. are women. The “women preferences” feature, designed to give both the rider and driver some control, could help attract more users on both sides.

Uber was the first major ride-hailing company to launch the women preferences feature. However, rival Lyft was the first to offer a [women-matching feature in the United States](#) — its primary market.

Topics: [ride-hailing](#), [Saudi Arabia](#), [Saudi Arabia](#)

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If you'll pay more, new Uber Comfort offers Quiet Rides

Josh Constone — 6:40 AM PDT · July 9, 2019

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colder temperature settings. These [Rider Preferences launched in May as part of Uber's pricier Black and SUV cars](#) alongside a way to request help with luggage, but now they're becoming more affordable.

The move allows Uber to charge more for slightly better vehicles and higher-rated drivers that used to be lumped in with its budget UberX tier. This also lets Uber compensate drivers better if they're willing to forgo the small talk or crank the air conditioning. "Uber Comfort should result in fares for drivers that are at least 20% higher than UberX (not including surge or promotions) for a trip with

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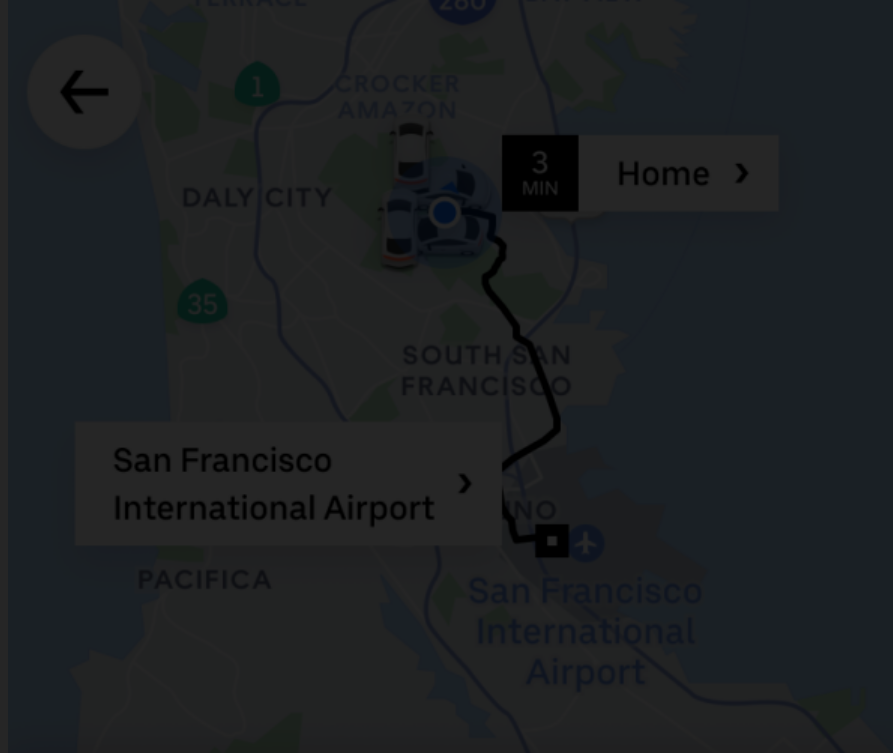


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Uber

Uber Cash – \$56.12

Choose Comfort

the same time and distance,” an Uber spokesperson tells me.

Some critics consider the Quiet Ride button an affront to the dignity of Uber’s contractors, saying it makes them act like robots when their jobs will soon be threatened by self-driving vehicles. But others just see it as enhanced customer service

that's reasonable to request, given riders are paying for a driver's professional services.

"The reception to Quiet Mode has been generally positive among drivers and riders," an Uber spokesperson tells me. "Riders appreciate the consistency and control they have over the type of their travel; business travelers in particular have shared how rider preferences have helped them be more productive en route to the airport, important meetings, or other work-related destinations. Drivers have shared how these new rider preferences have helped take the guesswork out of riders' expectations, and helped them provide the best

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To qualify for Uber Comfort, drivers need a car that meets higher and consistent vehicle make, model, year and legroom requirements, like the Toyota Camry, Honda Odyssey or Chevy Tahoe. They also must maintain a 4.85 or higher rating to be eligible. If these drivers don't want to receive Rider Preferences requests, they can opt out of being classified as Uber Comfort.

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Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

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hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

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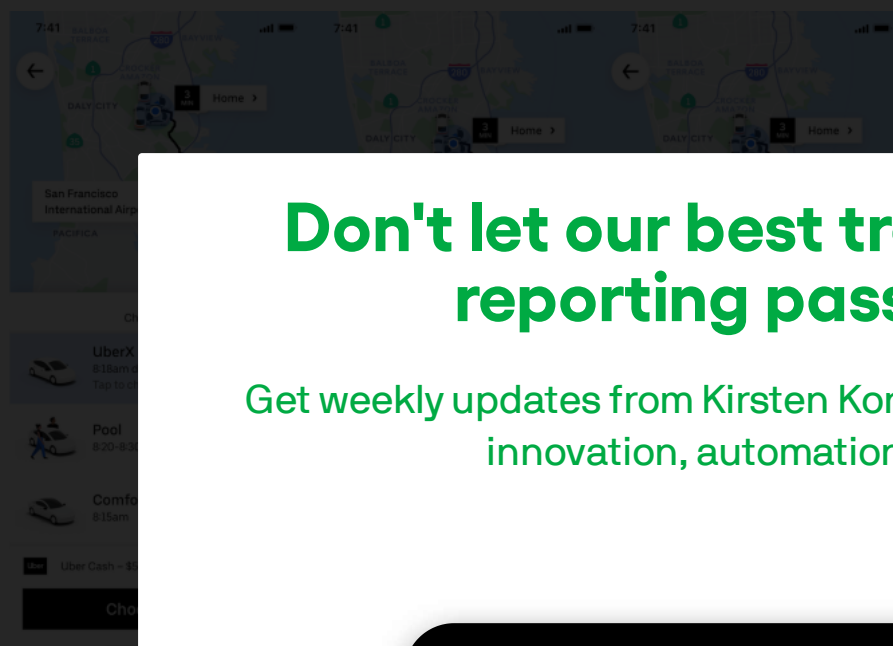
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Uber Comfort – 20% to 40% more than UberX for Rider Preferences like Quiet Rides plus better-rated drivers, nicer cars and minimum legroom requirements

Uber Select – Even more expensive for high-end cars but no Rider Preferences

Uber Black & SUV – The highest price for Rider Preferences, including luggage help and premium town cars or big vehicles



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Back in
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work or

awkward having to ask drivers mid-ride for quiet, as some would become offended or even hostile.

That's especially problematic for women, some who said their male drivers' probing questions would escalate to unwanted flirtation. Uber needs to do better at training drivers that this is unacceptable and weed them out of the system. But the reactive approach of waiting for negative ratings to come in after drivers have annoyed passengers can be augmented by allowing riders to ask for quiet ahead of time.

Bringing Rider Preferences to a wider swath of its vehicles could help Uber differentiate itself from competitors like Lyft and squeeze more cash out of passengers by training them to use its upgraded tiers as it tries to maintain momentum in the public market. Two months after its IPO, it's finally recovered and exceeded its opening price.

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Uber expands green rides option to 1,400 cities

Kirsten Korosec — 7:43 AM PST · January 12, 2021

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Foxconn sells former GM factory to mystery buyer after failing to make EVs

Sean O'Kane - 2 days ago

Uber has also partnered with Ample. Starting this month, drivers in San Francisco can rent a vehicle with Ample battery swapping technology, which lets them switch out the electric vehicle batteries in minutes.

The company has also expanded its partnership with EVgo to give drivers on its ride-hailing platform access to charging discounts at more than 800 U.S. locations.

Uber's zero-emission goal will require more than getting drivers and riders to use EVs. The company is expanding other programs as well, including its journey-planning feature for public transit users.

The feature is available in cities like New York and lets users include transit in their trip time so they can better plan. Uber added the feature in Brisbane, Australia, and Rome, Italy.

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Uber said it is also bringing to Mexico City and London a multimodal trip planner that combines ride-hailing with walking directions and city bus, subway or train connections. The feature launched in Sydney and Chicago.

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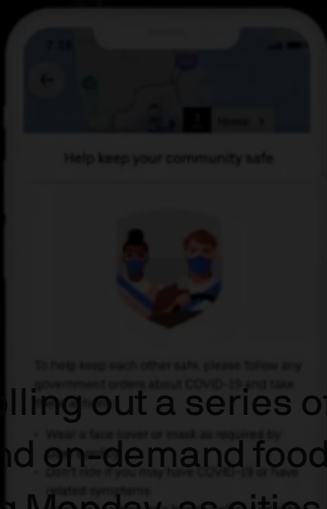
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Here's how your Uber ride will change, starting May 18

Rider

Kirsten Korosec — 1:06 PM PDT · May 13, 2020



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“This is not a problem that can only be solved by the drivers or only can be solved by the riders, it is everyone’s responsibility,” said Sachin Kansal, senior director of product management at Uber, during a webinar Wednesday announcing the changes.

User policing lies at the heart of these new policies. Riders and drivers, as well as delivery workers and even restaurants that use Uber Eats, will have the power to report unsafe COVID-19 behavior and give low ratings. For instance, a delivery worker can give feedback that a restaurant doesn’t have proper protocols in place, such as social distancing.

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Meanwhile, a restaurant can provide feedback if a delivery driver isn't wearing a mask.

"These feedback loops between all the parties are extremely important for us to maintain safety," Kansal said.

The new policies will remain for the next several months, according to Kansal, who added that "as the situation on the ground changes, we will evolve our policies as well."

All Uber app users will now have to read and agree to an online checklist before picking up a rider or trying to hail a ride, according to the company. The

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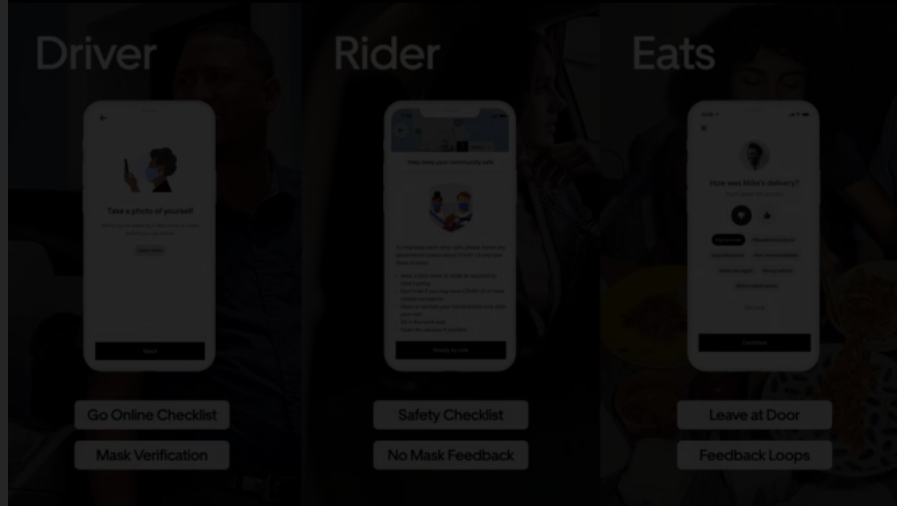


IMAGE CREDITS: UBER

Uber will encourage drivers and riders to cancel trips — a move that in the past could result in a lower rating — if they don't feel safe or the user is

not wearing a mask. Drivers will have to verify they're wearing a mask before accepting trips, using Uber's existing driver selfie technology. The app also features a video tutorial on how to wear a mask.

Kansal said the platform requires drivers to

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Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

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